

Lesson 11: Negotiating Salary

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One of the most common negotiations you'll face in your career is how to successfully negotiate your salary. Whether it's negotiating at the onset of a job or during your position in a certain role, *how* you negotiate your salary is key.

For women, mastering this skill is especially important in addressing the gender pay gap and ensuring fair compensation. By doing thorough research, knowing your worth, and approaching the negotiation with confidence and professionalism, **YOU** can make sure you get paid the salary you deserve.

We'll go over a few things to *Do* and *Don't* here.

First off, a few things to *Do*:

Research your market value. The first step in salary negotiation is understanding your worth. Consider your qualifications, experience, and the responsibilities of the role. Studies show that women routinely dismiss or undervalue their skills, which can be an issue when negotiating salary. Arm yourself with data by researching industry standards.

Be armed with a range, not a number. When accepting a new position, know your range. What is your ideal salary? The lowest you would accept? Think about what you're working toward before the negotiation. *Don't* give out your range – that's just for your own guardrails.

Pick the right timing. Timing can *significantly* influence the outcome of a salary negotiation. Ideally, try to negotiate after a successful project or a performance review when your contributions are fresh in your employer's mind. Avoid negotiating during stressful periods for your company or immediately after a budget cut.

Get everything in writing. Sometimes a salary increase is promised after the first 90 days, or they may communicate that you just had a raise and need to wait six months before they can get another approved. That's fine, but ask if you can have that in writing from your supervisor. Tell them you understand, but want to make sure that the promise is documented, so there won't be confusion later. Remember the saying, "If it's not in writing, it's not real."

Keep emotions out of it. OK, this is easier said than done. We're talking about your salary after all – your bread and butter! – but try to stay focused on the facts and avoid getting emotional during the discussion. Remember, *you* are a highly talented, competent

individual, and this is *not* your only option in the workforce (even if it's a job you love and don't want to leave). Putting too much pressure on the discussion will only make you emotional, which can come off as desperate. Do your best to keep emotions out of it and pick a time that you can calmly and rationally make your pitch – not immediately following a downsizing to a single-household income or right after bad financial news. That in itself shouldn't be the motivating factor for a raise.

All this being said, the art of negotiating salary is as much about knowing what *not* to do as it is what to do.

Here are some things you want to *avoid*:

Don't focus on the negative: "I need to be paid more for what I put up with." or "I've taken on more work in the last year and my salary hasn't gone up." A salary increase should be based on the value you provide the company, not simply the hours you work. It may be true, but it's not helpful in a salary negotiation. *Don't* mention grunt work, stress or long hours. You want to focus on the *positive* – how you are adding *value* to the company. You want to show so much ROI that you make them think they are practically saving money by keeping you on and giving you a raise!

Don't compare yourself to others: "I don't get paid nearly as much as [fill-in-the-blank.]" Leave other people out of it! Their salary is their business and your salary is yours. Plus, it won't help your case. It will only make your employer defensive.

Don't wait until you are actually in your annual review with your supervisor to talk about salary. Most salary increases have to be approved months in advance. Go on the offense here – 90 days out is a good window. If you need a salary increase, let your supervisor know a few months in advance of your annual review: "My annual review is coming up in January. I'd like to sit down before then to go over some of my recent contributions and discuss some future topics." This gives you an opportunity to go on the offense outlining the value you provide, backed up by any data, and let your supervisor know that you think a raise of X amount would be fair. It then gives them time to work on the request prior to your review.

Don't be inflexible. Negotiation is a two-way street. Be open to discussion and compromise. Be prepared for counter offers. If the employer can't meet your salary expectations, explore other areas such as additional benefits, flexible work arrangements, or performance-based bonuses. You don't have to automatically accept, but it's important to be open-minded.

Don't expect an answer on the spot. Don't be too frustrated if the other party needs to review your salary offer. Many times your direct leader isn't the only person who has to sign off, so be prepared for a slight delay. But be prepared with an acceptable time frame: "I

know my annual review isn't for eight months, but I've taken on a new role and added a lot of new value to the company. What can you do in the next 90 days?"

Finally, don't throw down an ultimatum: "If I'm going to stay here long term, I need a salary increase." This starts the negotiation out on the wrong foot. This should only be used if you are truly prepared to walk out the door that moment, as in, you have another job lined up. Don't let it get to this point! With successful salary negotiating, you can head off the need for any ultimatums at the pass.

In a nutshell, negotiating salary is a skill that can significantly impact your career trajectory. Just like any skill, it has to be developed – and it can be learned!

Remember, negotiation is not just about the money – it's about recognizing your value and taking control of your career.

You've got this!